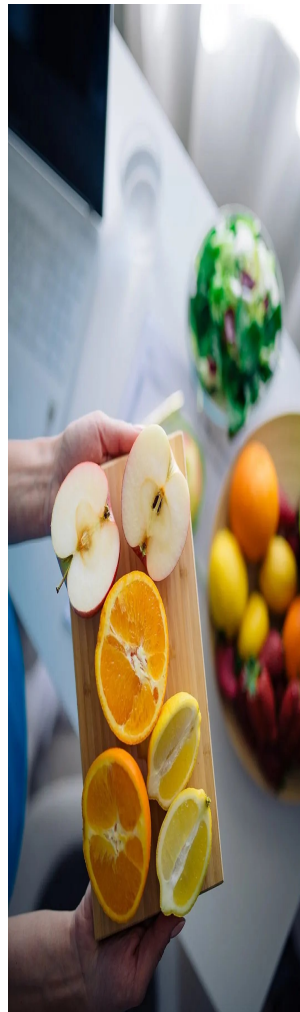


Turmeric for Arthritis: Does It Really Work?

Explore the science behind turmeric and curcumin for arthritis pain relief.
Evidence-based review of dosage, benefits and side effects.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Turmeric for Arthritis: The Science



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Turmeric is one of the most researched natural anti-inflammatories. Its active compound, curcumin, has shown genuine promise for arthritis — but the details matter.

What the Evidence Shows

Curcumin works by blocking inflammatory pathways (NF- κ B and COX-2) — the same pathways targeted by NSAIDs like ibuprofen.

****Key clinical findings:**** - Systematic reviews suggest around 1,000 mg/day of curcumin can meaningfully reduce arthritis pain and stiffness over 8–12 weeks - Some randomised trials report curcumin performing comparably to standard anti-inflammatory medication for knee osteoarthritis, with fewer gastrointestinal side effects - Multiple studies show benefits after 4–8 weeks of consistent use - Anti-inflammatory effects measured by reduced CRP and IL-6 levels



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The Absorption Problem

Curcumin is poorly absorbed by the body — only about 1% reaches the bloodstream on its own. Solutions:

- **Piperine (black pepper)** — increases absorption by up to 2,000%
- **Fat-based formulations** — curcumin is fat-soluble; take with meals containing healthy fats
- **Liposomal or nano-curcumin** — newer formulations with improved bioavailability
- **BCM-95 or Meriva** — patented formulations with proven absorption

Recommended Dosage



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| Form | Daily Dose | Notes | |-----|-----|-----| | Curcumin extract | 500–1,000 mg | With piperine | | Turmeric powder | 1–3 g | Cooking spice (lower curcumin content) | | Liposomal curcumin | 250–500 mg | Enhanced absorption |

How to Use Turmeric Daily

****Golden milk recipe:**** 1. Heat 250 ml oat or almond milk 2. Add 1 tsp turmeric powder 3. Add 1/2 tsp cinnamon, pinch of black pepper 4. Stir in 1 tsp honey 5. Simmer for 5 minutes

Safety and Interactions

- Generally safe at recommended doses
- May interact with blood thinners (warfarin)
- Can cause mild GI upset in some people
- Avoid high-dose supplements if you have gallstones
- Always inform your GP about supplements you are taking

The Bottom Line

Turmeric/curcumin has genuine anti-inflammatory properties backed by good evidence. It is not a miracle cure, but as part of an anti-inflammatory lifestyle, it can meaningfully support arthritis management.

Reviewed by Dr. Anil Patel, Consultant Rheumatologist, University Hospitals Birmingham

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about turmeric for arthritis: does it really work??

Short answer: Curcumin, turmeric's active compound, has reasonable clinical evidence for arthritis. Around 1,000 mg/day for 8–12 weeks appears to reduce pain and stiffness by blocking the NF-κB and COX-2 inflammatory pathways. Absorption from plain turmeric is poor, so use a piperine, phytosome or liposomal formulation and take with food.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk